

**Do Less, Better: A Marketing Plan for Pebble's Revival**

Group 11

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## Introduction

Pebble is a smartwatch brand launched in 2013 after a then record-breaking \$10.3 million Kickstarter campaign (Metz, 2016). 10 years after shutting down in 2016, it is currently going through a revival with three watches and a smartring in its production line (Migicovsky, 2025). In the 4 years after Pebble's wildly successful Kickstarter, Pebble sold over two million smartwatches with over \$230m in sales (Migicovsky, 2022), cultivating a thriving community of developers who created over ten thousand Pebble apps and watchfaces (Jeanson et al., 2025). After shutting down in 2016 and having its IP pass through Fitbit then Google, Migicovsky decided to relaunch Pebble in 2026, citing that he and like-minded folks wanted a watch like Pebble but none had appeared on the market (Migicovsky, 2025). Relaunching Pebble was still possible given that in 2025, Google made the Pebble OS open-source (Jeanson et al., 2025). Migicovsky believes that Pebble's rapid growth and feature expansion back in the 2010s made him lose sight of his initial vision for Pebble, and he's determined to learn from those mistakes (Heater, 2025). On his personal blog, he wrote, "Our marketing efforts (outside of the Kickstarter campaign) were pretty awful." (Migicovsky, 2022)

The goal of Pebble has always been simple: To build awesome smartwatches and other gadgets for people (Core Devices LLC, 2026). Pebble receives no funding from outside investors, and their devices are sold exclusively online through their official website, [store.rePebble.com](https://store.rePebble.com), and shipped internationally. Pebble's watches have five key features: an always-on e-paper screen, long battery life, simple and beautiful design, physical buttons, and a hackable interface (Core Devices LLC, 2026). Pebble's software is powered by an open-source PebbleOS, supported by an active developer ecosystem, which sets it apart from mainstream smartwatch brands. Despite

the Pebble hardware and software support being discontinued in 2017, Pebble still has thousands of dedicated fans to this day. This is a clear indicator that there are strong consumer bases for Pebble to tap on—they just need the right marketing strategy. Given that Pebble has done limited to no awareness campaigns beyond their Kickstarter, this report focuses on driving sales for Pebble through campaigns that increase consumer awareness of the brand and its offerings, specifically the Pebble 2 Duo (Migicovsky, 2025b).

### **Company and Market Situation Analysis**

Pebble has a strong brand legacy and a passionate community that supports its open-source OS and extensive app ecosystem. Although Pebble has suffered business failure in the past due to limited financial resources, showing up too early in the market where majority of the people wanted maximalism, and poor marketing execution, the brand offers a unique value proposition through its minimalist, long battery life, low price point, and customization opportunities. Now, in a more mature market, Pebble aims to leverage its existing fan base and aim for practical tech enthusiasts to dominate this specific minimalist/hacker niche market. (See Appendix A)

According to the Global Smartwatch Market forecast for the period of 2022-2027, the market is projected to continue grow fast with a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 14.83%, resulting in an absolute growth difference of \$31,385.89 million between the base year (2022) and the final year (2027). Geographically, the market is heavily influenced by North America, which is expected to contribute 42% of the total market growth. Structurally, the market is described as fragmented (Technavio, 2023). So, this gives Pebble an opportunity to expand its growth.

## **Market & Competitors**

The smartwatch market presents three product archetypes (The 5 Best Pebble Watch Alternatives, 2022). (1) the "do-everything" category (Apple Watch, Samsung Galaxy Watch), which functions as smartphone extensions, which consumes battery and may increase screen time. (2) the fitness-focused category (Garmin Fenix, Fitbit Sense), offering fewer features but higher in prices. (3) a hybrid approach combining niche functionality with extended battery life. Within the U.S., Pebble occupies this third (3) category as the only domestic brand producing such a device; Xiaomi and Huawei develop comparable products in China but have not yet affected the American market.

Examining specific competitors: Apple and Samsung offer extremely low battery life (18 hours to 2 days) at high price points (\$249–\$399+); Garmin provides 14 days of battery but it is focused on fitness, no personalizations, with an overly simplified interface, where as pebble allows one to fully hack and customize their experience. FitBit and Amazfit, budget friendly, also lower-priced, still requires weekly to 10 days charging and lacks open-source customization. Critically, no competitor combines what Pebble 2 Duo has (see Appendix B).

## **Pebble's Advantage over Competitors**

Pebble 2 Duo adheres to a user-oriented design concept. Its philosophy ensures that users can intuitively navigate and operate the device based on their pre-existing habits, eliminating the need for significant behavioral adjustment. This is achieved through a minimalistic design language encapsulated by the principle of "less is more." This design prioritizes core

functionality through the implementation of physical buttons, an e-paper screen, and a set of simple yet comprehensive functionalities perfectly adequate for general daily usage.

A significant competitive advantage for the Pebble 2 Duo is its exceptional battery life, offering a substantial battery life of up to 720 hours, which is 384 hours to 480 hours longer than to its competitors. Furthermore, the watch integrates a built-in microphone, enabling users to record voice messages for messaging without needing to access their paired smartphone.

Beyond the hardware, the Pebble 2 Duo excels in the user experience through its advanced health-tracking algorithms. It offers users sophisticated step and sleep tracking capabilities with accurate and actionable insights. User feedback consistently praises the precision of these algorithms, with some users on the Pebble OS platform describing the step and sleep tracking as "scary accurate" (jmjd00, 2025). For users who might find the "less is more" aesthetic restrictive, if any, the Pebble ecosystem offers an unparalleled level of customization and flexibility. The platform features a hackable, open-source ecosystem that empowers users to design and apply custom user interfaces or develop and deploy entirely new applications. This open-source strategy transforms the Pebble 2 Duo from a simple consumer electronic into a highly adaptable and personalized device capable of evolving with the user's needs and technical ambitions.

### **Product Focus & Rationale**

This report focuses specifically on the Pebble 2 Duo as it best represents Pebble's core value proposition and is the most market-ready product in the current lineup, with shipping beginning in July 2026 (Migicovsky, 2025). The Pebble 2 Duo directly addresses the core limitations of

today's smartwatch market — devices that are too expensive, too complex, or require daily charging, all within closed ecosystems that restrict customization. At \$149 with up to 30-day battery life and an open-source OS, it offers a combination no competitor currently provides (Core Devices LLC, 2026). Like Amazon's Kindle, which succeeded not by matching the iPad but by doing less and doing it well, the Pebble 2 Duo's strength lies in deliberate simplicity over feature overload. Furthermore, the sustained community engagement seen through Rebble.io and 10,000+ fan-built apps confirms that demand for exactly this type of product already exists (Migicovsky, 2022) — making the Pebble 2 Duo the natural focus for this marketing plan.

## Marketing Goals

The **primary** marketing goal is to establish Pebble as the leading minimalist smartwatch within the wearables market. There are two objectives supporting this goal: First, **niche market leadership**: capture 15% or more of the long-battery (>7 days) smartwatch segment in the U.S. markets. Second, **product credibility and reliability**: trust must be earned before marketing can succeed. This requires fixing known bugs (e.g., notification duplication, iOS setup failures) and improving warranty beyond the current 30-day term while ensuring advertised battery matches real-world usage.

Research shows searches for screen time reduction have increased drastically (Pieh et al., 2025), while families are trying to stay away from screen: the Light Phone—a phone that helps with screen time reduction—has sold out till September 2026 (The Light Phone, 2024), as well as the subreddit r/digitalminimalism grew from ~50,000 to 450,000 members between 2020 and 2026 (Reddit Statistics, 2026). This environment creates a favorable almost perfect opportunity for Pebble to establish leadership within this emerging category.

## **Target Customer**

Pebble's target customer base is characterized by practical tech enthusiasts with an active lifestyle, who are typically aged between 20 to 40 years old. These are people who prefer focused, practical products over those with numerous features and aesthetic nice-to-haves. They value efficiency, long battery life, open ecosystems, and products with a niche identity. Pebble appeals to them not because it is the most advanced smartwatch, but because it feels more intentional, customizable, and aligned with a functional mindset.

## **Value Proposition**

For practical tech enthusiasts with an active lifestyle (who are typically 20 to 40 years old), the Pebble smartwatch allows them to go about their daily activities with the help of essential, lightweight, and personalizable features without the need for daily charging or feature overload because it prioritizes long battery life, simplicity, and an open developer ecosystem, unlike competitors with complex, resource-heavy app systems.

## **Marketing Solution #1: Earned Media Strategy**

Pebble cannot compete with Apple's estimated billions annual ad spend (Matco, 2023). Instead, earned media strategy is what Apple cannot purchase (Radosavljevic, 2025): authentic, passionate fans and micro-influencers who believe in minimalism and pebbles' vision. The approach has three-stages: (1) gift devices to community members, (2) produce organic content, (3) boost posts across multiple official platforms, (4) convert engagement into sales via affiliate codes (Types of Earned Media and Their Impact on Your Brand, 2025). Within 90 days, the

earned media strategy is projected to generate 500,000+ earned impressions (purchases, likes, shares, follows). Total budget: ~\$25,000–\$30,000. Cost per acquisition through earned media is estimated under \$20, compared to \$50–\$100 for paid social. More importantly, the goal is credible, authentic content that resonates where paid advertising cannot (see Appendix C).

### **Marketing Solution #2: OOH Media Strategy**

The advertising strategy must learn from Pebble's 2013 failure, where relying solely on retailers like Best Buy and Amazon proved insufficient. The current solution requires a thoughtful approach that aligns with the design philosophy while maximizing outcome with minimal resources. To this end, the optimal out-of-home (OOH) media placement is in highly populated areas, such as targeting neighborhoods frequented by the desired customer base in New York City. Prime examples include the tech-centric areas of Dumbo and Chelsea, where tech professionals both work and potentially reside. The visual design should be minimalistic, featuring a plain white background and a simple, rhetorical slogan: "Why do you need more?" This statement is intended to provoke curiosity among target customers who see the advertisements on their commute. The expectation is that the ad's bold simplicity, despite the product's lack of features, will make a compelling statement.

### **Marketing Solution #3: Developer & Community Revival**

Unlike Solution #1 which targets general consumers through influencers, Solution #3 activates Pebble's developer community — a segment no competitor can replicate through its open-source ecosystem. The strategy runs in three phases: **Revive** — relaunch r/pebble and r/Rebble with a 'Pebble is back' announcement and developer AMAs to re-engage the existing community at



minimal cost; **Excite** — launch a Pebble Dev Challenge: an open competition for new watchfaces and apps, with prizes including early Pebble 2 Duo units and features on official channels. Similar to how Dr Pepper turned an organic fan-created jingle into a national commercial, the goal is to surface genuine community creativity and amplify the best outcomes — high engagement at low cost; **Amplify** — motivated developers organically share their work on X, YouTube, Hackernews, and Reddit, generating earned media among practical tech enthusiasts aged 20–40 without paid advertising. This directly addresses Pebble's past failure to build coordinated marketing campaigns (Migicovsky, 2022), while remaining authentically aligned with its open-source brand identity.

### **Distribution Channel**

Despite the initial failure in 2013, the business will now employ a direct-to-consumer distribution model, selling exclusively online in controlled, smaller batches. This approach offers three significant advantages over relying on retailers like Best Buy and Amazon. Firstly, this direct channel establishes the product as a niche item, allowing the Pebble website to define and deliver this exclusive "niche" identity. Secondly, the controlled production inherent in this model reinforces the niche positioning, as it contrasts with the perception of a mass-produced product. Finally, by owning the distribution channel, Pebble can reduce expected costs, such as retailer revenue shares and expenses related to rent, operation, and staff.

## **Marketing Performance Evaluation Methodology: Pebble Smartwatch**

### **A. Brand Preference & Positioning**

To evaluate brand preference for the Pebble Smartwatch, online surveys that include comparative

ranking questions such as Pebble vs. competitors like Garmin and Apple will help see the movement of brand preference. Also, sentiment analysis that collects mentions from platforms like Reddit and Discord and classifying mentions as positive, negative, or neutral will help quantify brand perception and tracking changes over time.

### **B. Conversion & Sales Performance**

A/B testing will be implemented to evaluate how different messaging, for example, “minimalist design” vs. “long battery life,” impacts sales conversion. Sales growth and targets will be assessed through monthly sales data compared against benchmarks that will change along with production ability and market conditions.

### **C. Engagement & Community Strength**

Social media engagement will be evaluated by tracking metrics of likes, shares, comments, and hashtags. Community growth will be measured by how many members join, leave, and actively participate in Pebble-focused groups on Discord and Reddit. Also, user-generated content (UGC) volume will be tracked by counting new watchfaces, apps, and shared modifications.

### **D. Retention & Loyalty**

Retention will be assessed through repeat purchase rate using customer purchase histories. App engagement will be measured via daily active users (DAU) and weekly active users (WAU), collected through in-app analytics tools. Customer lifetime value (CLV) will be calculated using average purchase value, purchase frequency, and customer lifespan. Churn rate will be determined by identifying users who stop engaging with the app or don't make repeat purchases.

## **Environment Analysis Methodology: Pebble Smartwatch**

### **A. Competitor Monitoring**

To help Pebble's strategic decisions remain informed by competitor innovations, monthly product scan reviews will be conducted on competitors such as Apple, Samsung, Garmin, and any other disruptive competitors. This will involve tracking new product launches, feature updates, pricing changes, and marketing campaigns.

### **B. Technology Trends**

Technology tracking will be conducted quarterly following industry reports, patent filings, and technology news, focusing on areas like battery technology improvements, wearable health sensors, and AI integration.

### **C. Consumer Behavior Trends**

Consumer behavior will be monitored semi-annually with surveys and social listening to check on demand for digital minimalism, health tracking expectations, and price sensitivity.

### **D. Economic & Market Conditions**

Macroeconomic and industry conditions will be tracked semi-annually using data from market research firms and financial reports to monitor how rising living costs influence consumer spending and to analyze industry expansion/contraction to contextualize Pebble's performance.

## **Conclusion**

In summary, this report describes a marketing plan for Pebble to drive consumer awareness and subsequently increase the sales of Pebble 2 Duo. The marketing plan consists of three strategies that focus on earned media that taps on existing fans, microinfluencers, and the growth of Pebble's developer community, along with OOH advertising campaigns to attract practical tech enthusiasts.

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## Appendix A

## Pebble SWOT Analysis

| STRENGTHS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        | WEAKNESSES                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Strong brand legacy &amp; passionate community (<a href="http://Rebble.io">Rebble.io</a>)</li> <li>• Unique value proposition: 30-day battery, e-paper display, &lt;\$150 price</li> <li>• Open-source OS &amp; established developer ecosystem (10k+ apps)</li> <li>• Minimalist, distraction-free design philosophy</li> </ul>        | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• History of business failure</li> <li>• Past marketing execution was poor</li> <li>• Known product bugs &amp; initial warranty limitations</li> <li>• Limited financial resources compared to major competitors</li> <li>• Niche appeal, not targeting mass market adoption</li> </ul>                          |
| OPPORTUNITIES                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | THREATS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Growing “digital detox” and minimalist trend</li> <li>• Increasing consumer fatigue &amp; burnout</li> <li>• Underserved market gap for simple, long-lasting smartwatches</li> <li>• Leveraging existing fan base for organic, “earned media” growth</li> <li>• Potential to dominate the specific “minimalist/hacker” niche</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Intense competition from giants (Apple, Samsung, Garmin) with vast resources</li> <li>• Rapid competitor advancements in battery tech, health sensors, &amp; AI</li> <li>• Economic pressures (inflation) impacting tech spending</li> <li>• Risk of mainstream brands adopting minimalist features</li> </ul> |

## Appendix B

| Brand             | Battery  | Price      | Display | Hackable<br>(Open Source) | Target User         |
|-------------------|----------|------------|---------|---------------------------|---------------------|
| Apple Watch       | 18 hrs   | \$399<br>+ | OLED    | NO                        | iPhone power users  |
| Samsung Galaxy    | 1-2 days | \$249<br>+ | AMOLED  | NO                        | Android mainstream  |
| Amazfit Active    | 10 days  | 129+       | AMOLED  | NO                        | Budget sports use   |
| Garmin Forerunner | 14 days  | \$199<br>+ | AMOLED  | NO                        | Serious athletes    |
| Fitbit Sense      | 6 days   | \$199<br>+ | AMOLED  | NO                        | Fitness beginners   |
| Pebble 2 Duo      | 30 days  | ~\$150     | e-Paper | YES                       | Minimalists/hackers |

Pebble's strategy rejects direct competition with industry giants, instead filling an uncontested market gap: long battery life, open ecosystem, minimalist design, and sub-\$150 pricing.

## Appendix C

| Tactic 1: UGC                    |                                                                                                            | Tactic 2: Influencer Partnerships    |                                                                                                           |
|----------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| The Rebble 100 Developer Program |                                                                                                            | Micro-Influencer Affiliate Marketing |                                                                                                           |
|                                  |                                                                                                            |                                      |                                                                                                           |
| <b>Who</b>                       | Top 100 most active members of the Rebble community (via subreddit and Discord post history)               | <b>Who</b>                           | 20-30 niche creators spanning multiple categories( i.e. lifestyle, men's fashion, etc.)                   |
| <b>What</b>                      | Free Pebble 2 Duo shipped prior to public launch                                                           | <b>What</b>                          | Free Pebble 2 Duo + affiliate commission (10% of sales) + flat fee (\$200-\$500 based on engagement rate) |
| <b>Cost</b>                      | ~\$15,000                                                                                                  | <b>Cost</b>                          | ~\$10,000-\$15,000                                                                                        |
| <b>Ask</b>                       | Honest review content across social media platforms; no scripts, no brand guidelines, no approval required | <b>Ask</b>                           | One dedicated video/post + one story; key messaging themes: "no distractions" & "30 days, no charging"    |
| <b>Timing</b>                    | Months 2-3                                                                                                 | <b>Timing</b>                        | Months 2-4                                                                                                |
|                                  |                                                                                                            |                                      |                                                                                                           |